

heavy hitters in Metal Gear Solid 2 and God of War but there were a massive number of titles that scratched pretty much every itch a gamer could have. In fact, the PS2 boasts a library of more than 4000 games! At the time, the power of the console was unmatched and developers were looking at ways of

maximising every bit of the PS2.

Did you want a sweet God of War/ Devil May Cry clone? There were dozens on the PS2. Ghost Rider, Blood Will Tell, the first Onimusha etc. It also helped that Devil May Cry kind of started out as a Double-A game and then turned out to be the juggernaut it is today, but

that's a story for another day. Did you want a third-person action game?

You were spoilt for choice on the PS2. By that era, game development was pretty much streamlined and larger publishers were looking at developing more games at a lower cost.

Usually, this meant some sort of cutback. Usually in the cut-scenes or smaller levels etc. What this did was force developers to really think out of the box. Games like Katamari Damacy had you play as a sentient adhesive ball that rolls around and collected increasingly greater objects, ranging from thumbtacks to people to mountains. The game was published by Bandai Namco and cost less than a million dollars to make. It went on to become a sleeper hit with 5 sequels arriving soon after.

The seventh generation of gaming also saw a bunch of Double-A games hit both the Xbox 260 and the PS3. It was during this time that the industry really started to change. With the added benefits of faster internet speeds, gamers could now just download their games onto their consoles. This meant that the need for physical discs and physical

marketing was nearing an end. Of course, the physical medium will never really fade out with diehards and collectors willing to shell out a pretty penny for physical/special edition copies of games. What began life as a Double-A game was now slowly being turned into what we now call Indie games. Games that are produced by a smaller studio, and are usually not affiliated with a larger publisher. In fact, the legacy and DNA of the Double-A game are very much present in a ton of modern titles. Hellblade; Senua's Sacrifice, Psychonauts, and more. In fact, even a gem such as Metro: Exodus could be somewhat classified as a Double-A game. Moving down the ladder, A game like Raji: An Ancient Epic could also realistically be looked at as a Double-A game for a modern audience. It's not the quality that's in question here but more the ability to experiment and push back against an increasingly sterile industry.

It's not that these kinds of games die out, it's just that they became something else. Bigger publishers were not willing to put their money into smaller games and with the cost of development becoming cheaper in many cases, it is now up to independent developers to truly carry on the legacy of experimentation set by the idea of the Double-A game. Maybe we will see a resurgence in smaller core experiences in video games but with the way the industry is heading right now, that might not be a remote possibility. The industry has shifted toward large big-budget releases that appeal to the largest audience possible. We will always have Steam and its myriad indie games and titles but again, with the way things are you have to sift through a ton of bad games to really hit gold. It also really does not help the industry when companies like EA and Activision exist.

Parasites like EA doing their best to squeeze out every drop of blood from gamers with microtransactions and other predatory practices while companies like RockStar have fallen victim to their own successes. But, with the rise and ease of use of engines such as Unity and Unreal 5, we could get titles that are weird and varied while still retaining the

